THE LEADING QUESTION AUTOPSY

Find the questions in your script that will get you lied to.

Not maliciously. Politely. Most people will tell a founder what the founder obviously wants to hear. This sheet finds the questions that invite it, and makes you rewrite them before you spend a real conversation on them.

15 MINUTES | 6 PAGES | PRINT IT · WRITE ON IT | BRING A PEN AND YOUR SCRIPT

YOU WROTE — ILLUSTRATIVE

~~"Would you use an app that automatically organises all your receipts?"~~

LEADING | HYPOTHETICAL | SOLUTION-BIASED

ASK INSTEAD

"Tell me about the last time you had to find a receipt."

three problems in one sentence ↑

01 · LEARN
The Three Tells: the three ways a question gives the answer away. (p.2)

02 · DRILL
Spot them in 12 illustrative questions, then check the key. (p.3–4)

03 · AUDIT
Run your own script through the test, score it, rewrite the worst. (p.5–6)

FREE TO PRINT AND SHARE. KEEP THIS FOOTER.

A question can give its answer away in three ways. We call them the Three Tells.

Start from first principles. An interview is a measurement. You want to measure what a person **has actually done**, because that is the closest thing to what they will do. Each Tell swaps that measurement for something cheaper: your opinion, their guess, or their politeness.

TELL 1 · LEADING

The answer you want is inside the question.

It tells them which reply is correct. Most people are kind to a nervous founder, so they pick it.

> *"Don't you hate chasing late invoices?"*

TEST → Could a polite stranger see which answer I'm hoping for?

TELL 2 · HYPOTHETICAL

It asks for a forecast, not a memory.

"Would you", "how much would you pay", "do you think people…". Asking someone to predict their own behaviour gets you an optimistic guess.

> *"If this existed, how often would you use it?"*

TEST → Is it about the future, or about other people?

TELL 3 · SOLUTION-BIASED

Your idea has walked into the room.

Once they know what you're building, they review your idea instead of describing their life, and they are polite about it.

> *"Our tool uses AI to auto-chase clients. Useful?"*

TEST → Does it mention my product, feature or idea?

NO TELLS · CLEAN

ask for a memory, get a story

"Tell me about the last time that happened." A clean question asks about a specific past event. It gets you a date, a workaround, a cost and a person: things that happened, not things they imagine. Then keep going: *What did you do next? What did that cost you? What have you tried?*

WHAT THE RESEARCH ACTUALLY SAYS

AND HOW SURE TO BE ABOUT IT

People say they'd pay more than they actually do. A meta-analysis comparing stated and real-money valuations found stated amounts were higher, with a median ratio of about 1.35×; other reviews report larger gaps.

Murphy, Allen, Stevens & Weatherhead (2005), *Environmental & Resource Economics* 30(3).

DIRECTION: SOLID

SIZE: VARIES A LOT

Changing what people intend changes what they do much less. Across 47 experiments, shifting intentions produced a noticeably smaller shift in behaviour, and the gap grew with time.

Webb & Sheeran (2006), *Psychological Bulletin* 132(2).

REPLICATED

HEALTH & SOCIAL BEHAVIOUR, NOT PURCHASES

One word can move the answer. People who were asked how fast cars "smashed" into each other gave higher speed estimates than people asked how fast they "contacted".

Loftus & Palmer (1974), *Journal of Verbal Learning and Verbal Behavior* 13(5).

CLASSIC LAB STUDY

AN ANALOGY FOR INTERVIEWS

Builds on Rob Fitzpatrick's *The Mom Test* and Y Combinator's "How to Talk to Users". This sheet is the drill, not the book.

Spot the Tells.

Twelve questions a founder of an invoicing tool for freelancers might ask. Tick every Tell you see. A question can have more than one. Tick **Clean** only if it has none.

ALL EXAMPLES ILLUSTRATIVE

	QUESTION	LEADING	HYPO-THETICAL	SOLUTION	CLEAN
01	"Would you use an app that automatically organises your receipts?"	☐	☐	☐	☐
02	"Tell me about the last time you had to find a receipt."	☐	☐	☐	☐
03	"Don't you hate chasing late invoices?"	☐	☐	☐	☐
04	"How much would you pay for something that fixed this?"	☐	☐	☐	☐
05	"What did you do about it the last time a client paid late?"	☐	☐	☐	☐
06	"Our tool uses AI to chase clients for you. Does that sound useful?"	☐	☐	☐	☐
07	"If this existed, how often do you think you'd use it?"	☐	☐	☐	☐
08	"What's the hardest part of getting paid for your work?"	☐	☐	☐	☐
09	"Wouldn't it be easier if your invoices just sent themselves?"	☐	☐	☐	☐
10	"Have you tried anything to fix this? What happened?"	☐	☐	☐	☐
11	"Do you think other freelancers struggle with this too?"	☐	☐	☐	☐
12	"On a scale of 1 to 10, how painful is invoicing for you?"	☐	☐	☐	☐

Before you turn the page: which one of these have you asked, word for word or close to it? No. _____

The key, and why.

If you disagree with a call, good: argue it out loud. The reasoning matters more than the tick.

	TELLS	WHY, AND A CLEANER VERSION
01	L H S	Pitches the app, asks for a forecast, and "would you use" has one polite answer. → *"Tell me about the last time you had to find a receipt."*
02	CLEAN	A specific past event. Follow with: *"What did you do? How long did it take?"*
03	L	"Don't you hate..." tells them what to feel. → *"Walk me through what happens when a client pays late."*
04	H S	Stated prices run higher than real ones (see p.2). → *"What have you paid for anything that helps with this? What do you pay now?"*
05	CLEAN	Past, specific, no idea mentioned. Dig into the workaround they describe.
06	L S	A pitch with a question mark at the end. Hold the solution back until you've heard the problem in their words.
07	H S	"If this existed" is both a hypothetical and your product. → *"How often did this come up last month?"*
08	CLEAN	Open and about their world. It's one of YC's suggested openers. Follow up with *"When did that last happen?"* to get from opinion to a story.
09	L S	"Wouldn't it be..." is the leading form, and auto-sending invoices is your feature in disguise.
10	CLEAN	Gold. What they have already tried, paid for or hacked together is the strongest signal that the problem is real.
11	H	Asks them to speculate about other people. → *"Who else have you talked to about this? What did they do?"*
12	L	Assumes it is painful and asks for an opinion score. → *"How long did invoicing take you last month?"*

YOUR DRILL SCORE

_____ / **12** rows fully right

Missed any? Circle them. A Tell you didn't spot on paper is one you're likely to ask out loud. Those are your blind spots.

Now do it to yourself.

Write the questions you actually plan to ask in your next interview, word for word. For each one, answer the four checks honestly. Any **yes** is a Tell.

A · SOLUTION
Does it mention my idea, product or feature?

B · FUTURE
Is it about the future, a "would", or other people?

C · LEADING
Is the answer I want hidden inside it?

D · COMPLIMENT
Could they answer "yeah, sounds great" and move on?

	MY QUESTION, EXACTLY AS I'D SAY IT	A YES?	B YES?	C YES?	D YES?	CLEAN (ALL NO)
1		☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
2		☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
3		☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
4		☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
5		☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
6		☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
7		☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
8		☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

CLEAN QUESTIONS

____ / 8

MOST COMMON TELL

A B C D (circle)

FIX FIRST

Any **B**. A forecast is the weakest data an interview can collect.

Be harsh. Then ask yourself honestly: would a stranger reading these questions have marked them the same way?

Before → after.

Take the three questions with the most Tells. Rewrite each one to ask about something that has already happened. Tip: start with "Tell me about the last time…" or "What did you do when…"

BEFORE	AFTER
BEFORE	AFTER
BEFORE	AFTER

THE PART PAPER CAN'T DO

You ask your clean opener. They smile and say: **"Oh yeah, I'd totally use something like that."** What do you say next, live, without pitching?

DID YOU MARK YOURSELF FAIRLY?

PAPER DOESN'T ANSWER BACK

Rehearse here. Learn out there.

Unassumed puts your questions in front of a synthetic customer who objects, digresses and refuses to be led. Then it scores **your questions**, not your idea. It's practice, not proof: a cheap place to find your leading questions before you spend a real conversation on them. Only a real customer is evidence.

Join the first cohort → unassumed.com

PRIVATE BETA · ONE EMAIL WHEN YOUR SEAT OPENS · NO DRIP SEQUENCE